

SOULKNIFE

PART ONE



Chapter 1

Menzoberranzan



There was no sky above Menzoberranzan, and there had never been one. There was only stone, rising so far above the city that even the sharpest eyes could not find where the cavern ended and darkness began. Menzoberranzan occupied a vast, arrowhead-shaped cavern, its roof nearly a thousand feet above the floor, while great columns and jutting shelves of calcite divided the space into layers. Bridges and walkways crossed the emptiness between them, joining towers carved directly from the living rock.

Some houses clung to the cavern walls, while others rose from the floor in defensive spires. Paths crossed the roof overhead, where powerful magic held homes and galleries against the stone, and from below, the highest districts seemed to hang above the city like a second, inverted world.

At the cavern's center stood Narbondel, a huge natural pillar of stone that served as the city's clock. Each morning, the Archmage warmed the stone to life, and a band of heat climbed slowly up the pillar as the day passed, read from almost every street, bridge, and balcony by eyes that saw warmth as the surface folk saw color. When the heat reached its end and faded into cold, Menzoberranzan entered its long night. No bell announced the hour, and no sun crossed a horizon; the city simply watched the stone.

Blue, green, and violet faerie fire burned across the city, outlining towers, gates, and house compounds in cold radiance, while pale fungi clung to the deeper walls and added their own weak glow. In some districts, the streets were bright enough for traders to display

their goods; in others, the light thinned until it became little more than a suggestion against the black.

None of it defeated the darkness. The light only gave the darkness edges.

A balcony could disappear beyond a veil of shadow, a bridge could seem to end where the stone fell away into blackness, and a doorway could stand open for years while no passing eye noticed what lay beyond it. To someone from the surface, Menzoberranzan might have seemed to exist in perpetual night, but to the drow, it was simply home.

And it was a city in every sense of the word.

There were streets crowded with movement, districts with their own character, workshops glowing around furnaces, warehouses filled with goods brought up from deeper tunnels, and markets where nearly anything could be found if one possessed the coin, the connections, or the willingness to ask the right merchant.

The Bazaar was a maze of voices and smells. In Duthcloim, merchants and craftsmen crowded together, trading food, weapons, fungi, cloth, poisons, curiosities, and stranger things whose origins were better left unasked. Slaves carried crates and baskets through the press of bodies, while a duergar merchant might haggle with a drow over a shipment and a goblin servant waited behind him with the next load. Guards watched the crowds without seeming to watch them at all.

In Narbondellyn, the streets widened, giving way to elegant estates, fashionable shops, skilled artisans, and houses wealthy enough to make their status visible in stone and metal. It was a district where reputation could be displayed as easily as jewelry, and where a passing glance at a doorway might tell an experienced drow more about its owner than the house name ever would.

Beyond it stood Qu'ellarz'orl, screened from much of the city by enormous mushrooms and guarded by distance as much as by force. The greatest noble houses occupied its heights, while commoners and outsiders did not wander there by accident.

Menzoberranzan had places for nearly everyone. It simply did not give everyone the same place.

The city was not silent. Footsteps crossed the bridges, merchants called from shadowed stalls, servants carried messages beneath the eyes of armed guards, and smiths struck heated metal. Somewhere deeper in the cavern, a slave shouted and was silenced. Noble processions moved through the traffic, and the crowd opened before them without needing to be told.

People knew how to make room. A merchant noticed a house emblem before he noticed the person wearing it; a servant recognized the rank of a passing noble by clothing, weapons, and the way those around her behaved; and a warrior saw a priestess approaching and changed his posture before she had reached him. Children learned these things without lessons because everyone around them already knew.

The city had been built in darkness by people who had learned to live inside it so completely that they no longer thought of darkness as the absence of anything. It concealed, protected, and gave the unwary somewhere to disappear; it was as natural to the drow as the stone beneath their feet—and just as unforgiving when someone misjudged its weight.

The darkness was also one of their oldest advantages. Drow eyes saw where surface eyes failed, heat marked the warm body hiding behind a cold wall, and a person standing still was still a person. Even a hand around a weapon gave off enough warmth to betray it.

The darkness was not empty. It was information.

Every shadow could contain a threat, an opportunity, or nothing at all, and the drow had spent thousands of years learning the difference.

They were not always what they had become. The stories taught to drow children told of an older people, elves who had once lived beneath open skies before Lolth and the conflict among the elven gods led her followers away from the surface. Those stories changed depending on who told them. Priestesses spoke of betrayal and divine

purpose; others remembered only that the drow had been driven down and that their enemies had stolen the world above.

Whatever the truth of those ancient days, the drow inherited the hatred.

It came before any child could understand the history behind it. Surface elves were not strangers in the way humans were strangers; they were kin who had become enemies, and the wound was old enough that no living drow could remember when it had first opened.

The drow lived in centuries. A single drow lifetime could outlast the rise and fall of human kingdoms, could watch generations of surface folk be born and die while the same dark eyes looked on. Their long lives gave them time to preserve grudges, refine crafts, remember names, and wait for opportunities that shorter-lived peoples would consider absurdly distant.

They also gave the city an unusually long memory.

A ruined doorway might still bear the insignia of a house that had fallen centuries ago. An old passage might have been widened because some dead Matron Mother had once needed her procession to pass through it, while a name spoken in one district might still carry the weight of a murder committed generations earlier.

Menzoberranzan remembered. Sometimes the living did not.

In those long years, the drow also carried the old world's gifts into the dark and bent them to their own uses. As children grew, they learned the powers inherent to their kind: lights appearing at a gesture, darkness gathering where it was commanded, magic capable of revealing a hidden target or lifting a body from the ground.

These were not wonders to them. They were birthright.

The city did not teach a drow child to marvel at such things; it taught the child to use them. A drow who could summon light learned that light could distract, a drow who could summon darkness learned that darkness could hide, and a drow who could make another body glow learned that being seen at the wrong moment could be as dangerous as being invisible.

Magic was part of life long before it became a profession.

The dark was never empty to them. They saw further into it than any surface eye, and they read it like a language. It was where they lived, where they had buried themselves, and where they had learned how to kill.

Spiders filled the city's architecture: carved into pillars, worked into doorways, raised above temples, and woven into the emblems of many houses. Some were beautiful, some grotesque, and some were so large that a child could stand beneath their carved bodies and still feel small. They appeared on jewelry, weapons, walls, shrines, and banners, serving as warnings, symbols, and reminders.

A drow learned early that there were some things it was wiser to observe than to touch, even when they were only stone. The city offered many such lessons.

Its towers belonged to houses. Its bridges carried traffic under the watch of whoever controlled the territory around them. Its markets belonged to merchants who understood which customers could be cheated and which customers could not. Its highest districts belonged to families whose names could change the way a room breathed.

Every path through Menzoberranzan passed through someone's power.

The city did not explain that power. It demonstrated it, and everyone who lived there learned to watch.

Chapter 2

The Web



Two male drow soldiers stood beneath an arcade of black stone while the traffic of Menzoberranzan passed around them. One wore the insignia of an armed spider, each of its eight legs gripping a different weapon; the other wore two spiders facing one another in a dark metal clasp at his shoulder. They had stopped to settle the delivery of a small alchemical consignment.

The soldier with the armed spider inspected the vessel before handing it back. “The third arrived with sediment. Four measures are due.”

The other soldier kept his gaze on the seal. “It left my stores intact. Three.”

The first soldier's thumb paused against the vessel's rim. “Then someone opened it between our stores.”

“Name the handler,” the second replied, his tone cool.

“We examined it before storage. Four.”

The soldier with the two-spider insignia gave a slight nod. “Very well. Have the next consignment arrive clean.”

They moved on, neither having raised his voice. There was no need. Each had tested the other's claim, neither willing to absorb the cost, and the matter had ended only when one decided the argument was no longer worth continuing. Courtesy had served its purpose without becoming trust.

The street was busy with the ordinary business of the city: merchants called to customers, slaves carried crates between stalls, and soldiers moved through the traffic in the colors of their Houses.

Then, gradually, the noise began to change. A merchant lowered his voice, a servant stepped against a wall, and two soldiers cleared the center of the street.

The priestesses were coming.

They appeared beneath the violet lights at the far end of the avenue, moving slowly through the traffic. They did not call for the street to be cleared because they did not need to. Drow moved aside before they approached, leaving a broad path through the market as merchants drew back their goods, slaves stopped where they stood and lowered their heads, soldiers stepped aside, and noble drow gave ground without protest.

The priestesses wore spiders openly: carved into collars, worked into metal, and hung from chains at their waists. Several carried ritual vessels; others carried banners.

The first banner bore the insignia of Baenre.

The second carried the mark of Teken'duis.

The two soldiers lowered their eyes.

A high priestess of Baenre walked beneath the first standard, surrounded by attendants and lesser priestesses. The Matron Mother of Baenre had not come; she had no need to attend a lesser House's punishment herself. A priestess of sufficient rank was enough to carry Baenre's authority, and her presence made the arrangement plain: the First House had been asked to stand as the hand of Lolth, while Teken'duis came to answer before it.

The Matron Mother of Teken'duis followed beneath her own banner, walking close behind the Baenre priestess. The difference between them was not measured only by the distance between their feet.

Baenre was first.

Teken'duis followed.

The street understood.

The procession continued into older passages beneath the noble quarter, where the markets thinned behind them, the walls narrowed, the light weakened, and spiders appeared more frequently in the

stone. The two soldiers followed far enough behind that none of the priestesses needed to acknowledge them.

The soldier with the armed spider kept his eyes on the procession. "The charge?"

The other soldier glanced once toward the Teken'duis banner. "Blasphemy."

Neither man asked the question that would have mattered more. The answer was already moving toward the chamber.

The passage opened into a circular chamber cut from the rock, and the soldiers stopped near the entrance. From where they stood, the entire chamber was visible: a low stone altar upon a raised circular platform at its center, black candles burning around it, and behind the altar a great carving of Lolth, her beautiful female form descending into the body of a monstrous spider, her legs spreading across the wall. The banners of Baenre and Teken'duis stood on either side of the altar.

The Baenre high priestess took her position before it, while the Matron of Teken'duis knelt behind her and other priestesses formed a wide circle around the platform.

Only then was the subject brought into the chamber.

He was a male drow of Teken'duis, dressed in formal House clothing, his wrists bound before him. His eyes were open, but he did not look at the soldiers or at the crowd; his movements were precise and obedient, as if every step had already been decided for him, while a priestess rested two fingers against the side of his neck and guided him forward.

The magic holding him was subtle. His body obeyed, while his mind remained unreachable. That was preferable for everyone involved.

A condemned male who shouted accusations through the streets, begged for his life, or named those who had arranged his fall could humiliate his House before the entire city, and Teken'duis would not permit that.

The high priestess raised one hand, and the chamber fell silent. When she spoke, her voice carried beyond the altar and into the chamber where every witness could hear it.

“Spider Queen, judge the unworthy. Take what has failed us. Strengthen those who remain. Let every eye remember what becomes of those who turn from your web.”

The lesser priestesses repeated the final words together, their voices turning the prayer into a warning that belonged to everyone in the room. The Matron of Teken'duis lowered her head.

The charge was pronounced by a priestess at the altar.

“Blasphemy.”

The single word gave the punishment its lawful shape.

Lolth's worship was not separate from the law of the city. Her priestesses were not merely keepers of shrines; they were the authorities through whom the goddess's order was enforced, and a drow accused of blasphemy could be placed beneath their judgment regardless of rank.

But the accusation was only the lawful face of the matter.

Teken'duis had been careful for some time. Its offerings had diminished, its public displays of devotion had become less confident, and failures that might once have been attributed to bad judgment or an unlucky rival had begun to gather a more dangerous interpretation.

Perhaps Lolth was displeased.

For a lesser drow, that thought might mean fear of punishment. For a House, it meant survival.

A House could lose cargo and replace it, lose soldiers and recruit others, or suffer a humiliating defeat and spend years rebuilding its reputation. What it could not afford was for other Houses to believe that Lolth had withdrawn her favor.

In Menzoberranzan, success was never only success. A fortunate campaign could be called Lolth's blessing, a prosperous season could be offered as proof of devotion, and a rival's failure could be taken as evidence that the goddess preferred another House.

Every victory therefore had a second audience.

Lolth.

That was why Houses competed so fiercely for rank, influence, and reputation. Wealth mattered, soldiers mattered, and knowledge mattered, but all of them were means to the same greater end: remaining in the goddess's favor.

Teken'duis had decided to make that calculation visible.

The accused male might have been guilty. He might have been forced into whatever act had been called blasphemy. Another drow might have arranged the circumstances and placed the blame upon him.

It did not matter now.

The charge gave the House a lawful victim. The sacrifice gave the House an opportunity. The difference between the two was thin.

A Matron could punish a blasphemer. She could surrender the condemned to Lolth. She could claim that the goddess had demanded judgment. She could not simply kill a member of her House and call the act devotion.

Not openly.

The laws of the city gave the Houses rules for their struggle, while Lolth's religion gave those rules their purpose. A House could scheme, compete, and destroy its enemies, but it still needed to preserve the appearance that its actions belonged within the order established by the Spider Queen.

Teken'duis was walking that narrow line.

The subject was brought onto the platform. The high priestess stood before him, the Matron remained kneeling, and the Baenre and Teken'duis banners rose behind them, making the hierarchy plain for everyone to see.

Baenre had sent a priestess because its authority did not require the presence of its Matron. The First House could lend Lolth's judgment to a lesser House without yielding its own importance. Teken'duis had brought its Matron because the condemned male belonged to it, and because the House itself needed to be seen making the offering.

The two soldiers watched from the entrance.

The high priestess touched two fingers to the subject's forehead, and the spell released.

His breath caught, his eyes widened, and for the first time since entering the chamber, he understood where he was. He struggled against the hands holding him, but the priestesses did not move aside.

The Matron of Teken'duis watched him. Her face was rigid, not with pity and not at the thought of what would happen to him, but with an attention fixed on the high priestess and the altar beyond her. She was waiting to see whether Lolth would accept what Teken'duis had brought.

That was the true purpose of the ceremony.

The House did not offer the male because his death was necessary. It offered him because the House believed that losing him might be worth gaining the goddess's favor again.

If ten males had been certain to win back that favor, Teken'duis would have had little difficulty surrendering them. The difficulty was not compassion; it was proving that the sacrifices were punishments permitted by Lolth's law rather than killings committed simply because the House desired them.

That was the balance every ambitious House understood: enough cruelty to satisfy the goddess, and enough law to make the cruelty acceptable.

The priestesses began to sing, their voices rising around the platform in measured praise of Lolth's strength and judgment.

"Spider Queen, judge the unworthy," the high priestess intoned.

The subject cried out.

"Take what has failed us," the priestesses answered, their voices steady even as his broke against them.

The high priestess lifted a ceremonial blade.

The Matron remained motionless.

The blade entered the male's chest beneath the House insignia. He convulsed, and his cry broke through the chamber before the priestesses drowned it beneath their voices.

No one looked away.

The Baenre priestess held him until his struggling ceased. The Matron of Teken'duis watched until his body became still, her face showing no triumph, only waiting.

Then the high priestess withdrew the blade.

The first part of the ritual was finished.

Priestesses of House Teken'duis gathered around the altar and began a longer prayer. Now the House would wait beneath Lolth's gaze.

The high priestess of House Baenre had more important matters to attend to. She gave a final instruction to the priestesses and turned away from the altar, the Baenre banner following her from the chamber. She had done what the First House had been required to do.

The soldier with the two-spider insignia remembered that he also had to hurry. He left without offering a word of farewell because there was nothing to say that mattered enough to delay him.

He moved quickly through the old tunnels, passed back into the busier streets, and hurried toward the district where his House stood.

Menzoberranzan had already returned to its ordinary rhythm. Merchants resumed their arguments, slaves carried cargo, and soldiers changed patrols while noble drow went about their business beneath the same darkness that had hidden the ritual from most of the city.

The soldier continued toward the House district.

Ahead, the dark towers of a drow House rose from the stone. Its galleries climbed the rock in severe lines, narrow balconies overlooked the streets below, and weapons marked the approaches. The two spiders, the unmistakable insignia of House Freth, the 19th of Menzoberranzan, faced one another above the entrance, watching the ever-moving city.

The soldier passed beneath its emblem and disappeared into the galleries.

Behind him, the city continued as it always had.

Lolth did not need to stand in every street. Her priestesses carried her authority, her hierarchy determined who could command, who could punish, who must kneel, and who could be offered, and her

Houses competed not merely against one another, but for the goddess's continued regard.

The web did not abolish chaos.

It gave chaos rules.

And the rules made the struggle serve Lolth.

Chapter 3

House Freth



House Freth was one of the lower houses of Menzoberranzan, and it did not forget what that meant. A house was family and faction, fortress and store of knowledge, the name that opened a door—or closed one forever. A house that appeared weak invited enemies.

House Freth had carved its halls into a broad rise of dark stone. Sweeping arches opened onto narrow balconies. Weapons hung where visitors could see them. The house insignia appeared on warriors' chests and bracers, worked into metal, and set above doorways: two spiders facing one another.

Carved spiders occupied every place where a reminder of Lolth seemed appropriate. The goddess took one spider for her symbol. House Freth had taken two, facing one another, and no one within the house confused the one for the others.

The house was alive with movement.

Warriors trained behind closed doors. Priestesses came and went according to duties the young could only guess at. Noble daughters learned the customs of their station and the names of families whose fortunes might someday matter.

The house never truly slept.

One of its rules was demonstrated in a long central hall.

A boy sat in the shadow of a doorway, his feet not quite reaching the floor. He had been sent there to wait. He had learned that being told to wait was not an invitation to ask why.

A male servant knelt in the middle of the hall.

The servant had made some mistake.

The boy did not know what it was. Perhaps the servant had carried a message to the wrong person. Perhaps he had spoken when silence was expected. Perhaps he had failed to anticipate what one of the household's priestesses wanted from him.

The reason hardly mattered.

The priestess stood before him in the dark finery of House Freth. She did not raise her voice. She did not need to. Her expression remained composed, almost bored, as though the kneeling servant were only an interruption to a more important thought.

The servant kept his head bowed.

A spider had been carved into the floor between them, its legs spreading across the stone beneath the violet light. The servant's gaze followed its lines.

For the briefest instant, his eyes rose.

He met the priestess's gaze.

The boy saw the change in her expression.

Not anger.

Decision.

The priestess lifted one hand.

A pulse of violet light passed through the servant's body.

He had time for a single, strangled breath before his flesh softened and collapsed inward. Skin blistered, darkened, and ran from bone. The smell reached the boy a moment later, sharp and sickening, but he did not move. He had been taught better than to react to a priestess's punishment.

The servant slumped onto the stone floor, already more liquid than flesh.

The priestess lowered her hand.

For one heartbeat, the hall was silent.

Then the household resumed its work: a servant carrying a tray stepped around the remains without spilling a drop, another fetched a cloth, and a passing warrior glanced once toward the floor before continuing on his way.

No one looked surprised.

The boy watched them, trying to understand what had happened in the only way he knew how: by memorizing it.

The priestess had not needed to explain the punishment.

The servant had looked where he should not have looked.

That was enough.

The remains were cleaned away while the priestess casually continued on her way, her silence a command for the hall to settle back into its usual rhythm as though nothing worth remembering had happened there.

The boy remained in the doorway for another few moments before climbing down from the ledge.

Later, he would learn that the newest slaves had been taken from a surface settlement and brought down into the city. They had not learned easily. Humans, the household had discovered, were poor slave material: too stubborn, too independent, too inclined to believe that defiance still meant something.

Still, they smelled better than goblins.

The boy did not call the scene cruel. He had no word for cruelty that belonged to him.

It was simply one of the things that happened in House Freth, and House Freth was the only home he had ever known.

He stepped into the corridor.

Two servants approached from the opposite direction. They noticed him, moved aside, and lowered their eyes just enough to acknowledge the difference between them. One nearly dropped the folded garments he carried while hurrying to clear the passage.

The boy did not comment.

The boy understood the hierarchy without ever needing to recite it. He had learned it from the way people moved around one another. His blood gave him a place above the servants.

He knew which corridors were safe to cross and which should be avoided. He knew to move aside when a group of noble females approached, before they reached him. He knew to lower his eyes when a priestess entered a room. He knew that a Matron Mother's attention was not something a male child sought.

He did not wonder why.

He simply knew.

The architecture of House Freth unfolded around him as he walked: smooth arches disappearing into darkness, stairways leading to higher galleries, carved stone depicting spiders and webs. The insignia appeared everywhere, familiar enough that he no longer paid attention to it.

The boy absorbed these lessons without resistance.

He had not yet learned to want anything else.

Somewhere beyond the halls, the city continued its endless life. Merchants argued over the price of shipments. Priestesses delivered commands. Noble houses exchanged polite words whose meaning mattered far more than their tone.

Somewhere, a child was being taught to pray to Lolth.

Somewhere else, another child was learning how to kill.

Menzoberranzan had existed long before the boy was born, with its own rhythms, grudges, traditions, and memory. Houses rose and fell. Names disappeared, and new names took their places.

The city did not care which child watched it endure.

For now, the boy was only one more child within House Freth.

A male among thousands.

A small piece in a city built from larger pieces.

There was nothing remarkable about him.

Nothing that demanded the attention of a goddess.

And yet he had a name, the way everything in this house had a name that carried its use in front of it.

His name was Laynlindr Freth.

Chapter 4

A Normal Day



At ten years old, Layn had learned that a day in House Freth did not begin with sunlight, for there was no sunlight beneath Menzoberranzan; it began when the house changed its lights.

The dim violet glow in the sleeping corridors faded toward blue, and the magical lamps set into the walls brightened one by one. Servants moved through the passages carrying water, clothing, and messages, while somewhere above, a bell sounded once—not to mark morning, but to announce that the household had begun expecting things from its people.

Layn woke before the second bell because he had learned that being woken by someone else usually meant he was already late.

His room was a narrow chamber set below the better apartments of the noble females. It was not a servant's room: the walls were faced with smooth black stone, the bedding was clean, and a small carved spider watched from above the doorway. Yet the room was plain, and its plainness made the distinction clear. He was noble by blood, but young, male, and unimportant by every other measure that mattered in House Freth.

He dressed in the clothes laid across the foot of his bed, folded the blanket, and left.

The corridor outside was empty except for a single female servant carrying a tray. She saw him and froze, pressing herself against the wall with her eyes down and the tray trembling in her hands. Layn read where the morning had gone without being told; she had not spoken at all, and few people in the house did.

He walked toward the lower hall.

The first meal was not a family gathering in the way surface stories described such things. No one sat together because they wanted one another's company; the household ate where rank and schedule placed them, and conversation moved toward whoever held the most authority in the room.

Layn took his usual place at the far end of the table, below the older males and behind the younger daughters, keeping his hands still while servants placed a cup of bitter rothé milk and a dish of spiced cave fungus before him.

His elder sister, Dreydre, sat three places closer to the head of the table. She had lived a century—young, still, by the measure of the drow—and already carried herself as though the house had begun making room for her future. Her posture was perfect, her voice quiet, and she never had to repeat an order.

Greyanna sat beside her. At sixty, she was younger still, yet her manners were already as flawless as her sister's; her smiles arrived at exactly the right moments—someone else's embarrassment, a small injury, a lesson landing on its target—and her eyes rested on such things a heartbeat longer than courtesy required.

Neither sister looked at Layn when the Matron Mother entered.

The room changed around her. Servants stepped away from the center aisle, the older males lowered their heads, and the daughters straightened, each of them suddenly more attentive to the angle of her shoulders and the placement of her hands.

The Matron Mother crossed the hall surrounded by two armed females of her guard. Her robes were the dark red of dried blood, embroidered with House Freth's paired spiders facing one another. She did not hurry; the household adjusted itself to her pace.

Layn rose with everyone else.

The Matron Mother stopped beside Dreydre, her gaze settling on her elder daughter with the calm expectation of someone who had already decided what would happen.

"The eastern gallery will receive the visitors," she said. "You will be present."

Dreydre inclined her head. “Yes, Matron Mother.”

The Matron Mother’s eyes remained on her. “And you will not let your sister speak for you.”

Dreydre lowered her gaze, accepting the correction without testing its limits. “Of course.”

The Matron Mother moved on.

Layn remained standing until the women had taken their places, then sat when the older male beside him lowered himself into his chair. The Matron Mother never looked in his direction.

That was normal.

He did not know whether she remembered that he existed or whether she had ever heard his name. When he was younger, he had sometimes tried to catch her attention by sitting straighter, arriving first, or being silent longer than was required, but each attempt had ended the same way: her eyes passed over him as though he were part of the wall.

He had stopped trying.

It was how a family was arranged. The house stood at the top, his mother carried the house, the daughters carried the name, and the males carried what was left. He had never thought to question the shape of it any more than he questioned the stone it was carved from. Being passed over was not a wound. It was a place, the way a stone in a wall is a place, and he had been born into his.

The first lesson began after the meal, as it always did. House Freth educated its children inside the house until their twentieth year; the daughters were taught the relationships between noble families, the moods of priestesses, and which alliances strengthened a bloodline, while the males learned enough of those matters to avoid interfering with them. The alliances lasted as long as they were useful.

Mistress Zilvrae taught Layn in the house’s library, above the training galleries.

She was a narrow-faced female with white hair braided tightly against her scalp. She had been born a daughter of a lesser house that House Freth had destroyed and absorbed. When a house fell, its surviving nobles were sometimes taken in rather than killed, and she had outlived her own name by serving the house that had ended it. Her rank was real, her house was gone, and that was why even the older daughters treated her corrections as something to be endured rather than challenged. Her lessons were called instruction, but her true subject was obedience.

The lesson was not private. Dreydre sat at the far table with the house's correspondence, while Greyanna sat in the window seat, turning a silver pin between her fingers.

Zilvrae set five emblems on the black table, in a line—five houses of Menzoberranzan, arranged in the order of their power. The city kept a rank of houses, fifty of them counting the lesser ones, and House Freth stood nineteenth on it.

Zilvrae tapped the first emblem with one finger and watched Layn's eyes settle on it. "This is the order. Look."

Layn studied the symbols: a silver blade, a broken chain, a spider above a crescent moon, and a crown surrounded by nine points, all of them familiar from the household records he had been allowed to read.

She swept the emblems up, shuffled them, and set them out again. Without looking away from him, she said, "Now you."

He set them in the order of their houses' power.

The order was wrong: the broken chain lay where the silver blade belonged and vice versa.

Zilvrae touched the misplaced emblem with the end of one finger. "You looked," she said, her voice patient but unsparing. "You did not see."

She gathered the five and laid them out in their order once more, one by one.

This time Layn did not watch the emblems. He watched the order itself. When she swept them up, the order did not go with them; it

stayed fixed behind his eyes, whole and silent, the way a shape stays after the light is gone.

She gathered the emblems without further explanation. "Again."

He set the five without a mistake.

She shuffled them and added five more.

The pin in Greyanna's fingers stopped moving. She was unsure whether she would have managed to outmatch her brother, were they to compete at that exercise at his age, and the muscle beside her mouth tightened.

Layn ordered all ten emblems without a single mistake.

Zilvrae shuffled the ten and added ten more, then ten more: twenty, thirty. The order waited behind his eyes until his hands needed it, and Layn set them in order every time, flawless each time.

When the thirty stood ranked on the black table, Zilvrae looked down at them, and despite herself something like approval escaped her, barely a whisper, almost an admission she had not meant to make aloud.

"Good memory."

Layn looked up at her.

Her expression closed again, the concession already withdrawn. "You remember what you have been shown. That is not the same as understanding it."

When the drill ended, she gathered the emblems and began the day's house lessons: how the rank had held in the city so far, what each house was known for, and House Freth's own craft, its substances. Venoms and alchemical preparations drew out what a creature already carried and did not care what they cost the vessel. Layn stood without shifting his weight and did not speak before he was spoken to; when he was correct, she said nothing. Her silence was her only verdict.

The tutor had many ways of teaching a child what not to expect.

Layn would soon discover that his sisters had more.

Greyanna found him in the passage outside the records room. She planted herself in the middle of it and looked down at him, studying him for a moment before smiling as though she had found an opening.

“You remember too well.”

Layn said nothing.

Her smile thinned. “It is not a rare talent. Do not look as though you expect praise.”

Layn knew there was no right answer.

Greyanna let the silence stretch before adding, “My pin is gone.”

The young male could not hide his confusion.

Layn answered quickly, anxious to keep the accusation from settling on him. “I have not seen your pin.”

Greyanna stepped closer, watching his face instead of his hands. “You were in the records room. You came out with your sleeves closed.”

Layn opened them. They were empty.

Greyanna smiled and did not look at his hands.

“Mistress Zilvrae was with me,” Layn said.

Greyanna's voice remained level, almost mild. “So you would have me believe your tutor stole it?”

She lifted one shoulder, feigning disappointment. “It was in my fingers all morning. You were there the whole time.”

He had seen servants punished for theft. None of them had been guilty either, so Layn went still.

The panic sank beneath the stillness like sediment in water left alone, and in the quiet it left, something pressed lightly behind his eyes.

It was not pain. He knew where the pin was—not because he had seen it hidden, not because he had reasoned it out, but because the knowledge was simply there, finished and certain, like a thought that belonged to someone else.

He said it partly to test whether the strange certainty was real. “In your right sleeve.”

Greyanna wore the look of someone about to be proven right. It lasted until he finished speaking. Then it was surprise, and she did not manage to hide it.

Her right hand drifted to her sleeve, the way a hand drifts when it has nowhere else to go. She drew out the silver pin and held it where he could see it.

Dreydre stood behind her, half-hidden by the archway. For a moment, her expression held something Layn could not name. It was not anger. It was not surprise. It looked almost like fear.

Then it was gone.

Greyanna's surprise vanished behind a smile. She drew the pin free and held it between them. "I put it there myself. To see what you would say."

Layn watched her carefully. "Then you already knew what I would say."

Greyanna stepped close enough that Layn could smell the bitter oil in her hair. "Do not become clever with me, boy." Her voice was quiet, but the warning in it was unmistakable.

Dreydre lifted one finger.

Greyanna fell silent.

The older sister took the pin from Greyanna's fingers and turned it once in the lamplight.

"You saw where this one fell," Dreydre said, studying Layn over its edge.

Layn shook his head. "I did not."

Her eyes narrowed slightly. "Then know where it is now."

She held the pin up between two fingers, where the whole passage could see it, then let go. The pin did not fall; it hung in the air, turning slowly in the lamplight.

A small spell—the luth, the first trick a daughter learned. It cast a thing a short distance, and it chose the where itself. Larger workings borrowed that randomness, so that even a spell the enemy knew by heart could still cause some form of surprise.

Dreydre raised both hands beside it, fingers spread, and spoke while it hung there. "When it leaves the air, it will be in one of my

hands. You will say which before it goes. If you are wrong, she will have her thief.”

It came again, the pressure behind his eyes, and this time he knew it was not his. The thought arrived finished, the way it had when he named the sleeve. It moved from the pin to Dreydre, then toward him. He felt the direction of her attention before she spoke.

Layn's answer came without hesitation. “Right.”

The pin still hung in the air, neither hand having claimed it yet.

And suddenly, the pin vanished.

Layn pointed at her right hand.

Dreydre looked at him and slowly opened her right, revealing the shiny silver pin.

Neither sister spoke.

The pressure behind Layn's eyes faded. He looked from the pin to Dreydre's face.

Greyanna stared at him, her certainty cracking. “How did you—”

Dreydre cut her off with a single glance and closed her fingers around the pin before Greyanna could say more.

“A lucky guess,” Dreydre said flatly.

Layn had not guessed, but he was wise enough not to say so.

Dreydre's fingers tightened around the pin. “You will not mention this.”

Layn watched her face. “Mention what?”

Her gaze hardened. “Our little game.”

He understood the warning and tested it anyway. “It was only a guess.”

“That is exactly why there is no reason to mention it,” Dreydre replied.

She turned toward the doorway. “Leave.”

Layn went. Greyanna held his eyes until the archway took him, and the look she gave him made the passage feel narrower.

Dreydre waited until Layn was beyond the archway before looking at Greyanna. “Tonight.”

Greyanna's earlier confidence was gone. She nodded.

Chapter 5

The Two Spiders



The order had come down years ago with no reason attached: the boy was to be given room—no marks, no cruelty—and watched. If the gift showed itself, it was to be suppressed before it could speak. Their mother did not explain her commands, and the house did not ask for explanations.

Obedience had rankled. There was cruelty in the house that would have been theirs to take, and the order had taken it from them. So they had done what the order asked. They had watched, tested, and learned little until tonight.

The years had left them a ledger, and this day had added to it. That morning, the boy had stood through four hours of instruction without once shifting his weight, and his answers had come as though the questions had been asked of him before. He had set thirty houses in order without hesitation, at an age when his instructor could not have done it. No one had shown him the watched stairs; he avoided them anyway. One evening, a servant reported that a lamp had cracked above a corridor after the young drow had passed beneath it. The servant was accused in the boy's stead and did not live to see another dusk.

They were not certain. Perhaps the boy was only quick, only lucky, only strange. But they had given him years of a calm they had never wanted him to have because a frightened mind hides its hand and a clear one shows it, and the hand had begun to show.

If they waited longer and the gift surfaced on its own—in front of a priestess, in front of their mother—no one would ask how to contain

it. They would ask who had let it grow, and the answer would have their names in it.

The order had told them to wait for signs. The signs had come. Nothing in it had said how gently the remedy must be given.

The boy's mind could not be allowed to speak first.

Layn walked back through the house knowing which stairs were watched, which servants repeated everything they heard, and which doors could be opened without making a sound. He had never been told any of it; the knowledge was simply where the house was, and he assumed the others knew their own ways as well.

He had learned only that the quickest route through the house was rarely the safest and that being overlooked could be more useful than being noticed.

No one praised him for these discoveries.

No one needed to.

When the house lamps dimmed toward the end of the household's cycle, Layn returned to his room.

The door was open.

He stopped before entering.

Two spiders rested on his bed.

They were not the small creatures carved into the walls or the delicate things that sometimes appeared in temple offerings. These were black and heavy-bodied, each with legs long enough to reach from the center of the blanket to its edge. Their movements were slow, deliberate, and disturbingly careful.

Dreydre stood beside the bed.

Greyanna sat on the windowsill, though there was no window beyond the dark opening—only a deep shaft crossed by a narrow bridge.

Layn's throat tightened.

He stared at the bed, fighting the urge to step backward. "Remove them," he said.

Greyanna smiled at his fear. "You know better than that."

Layn kept his voice low, as though saying it too loudly might make the room worse. "They are in my bed."

Greyanna glanced at the spiders, then back at him. "They are sacred animals of Lolth."

One of the spiders lifted its front legs and placed them on the folded blanket. Its body shifted with a faint, dry scrape.

Layn did not move.

Dreydre watched his hands rather than his face. "If you kill them, the Spider Queen will know."

Layn swallowed and forced himself to look at the spider nearest him. "They are not temple spiders."

Greyanna's smile sharpened. "You would question what is sacred?"

Layn's eyes stayed on the bed. "I only want them out."

Greyanna leaned against the wall and watched him calculate the alternatives. "Drive them away, then. Put them in the corridor. Let them wander into the servants' quarters. Let them crawl into someone else's bed."

She let the suggestion hang for a moment, then smiled wider.

"When the house suffers for your blasphemy, we will tell the Matron Mother who caused it."

Layn looked toward the corridor. No servant had come. No priestess had passed. His sisters had chosen a time when the room belonged to them.

Layn glanced toward the upper galleries before asking the question, as though the walls themselves might carry the answer. "Does the Matron Mother know they are here?"

Dreydre's expression hardened.

"The Matron Mother does not concern herself with a male child's bedding," Dreydre said, her composure returning.

Layn studied her face. "Then why would she care if I moved them?"

The answer came too quickly. "Because she would care about the consequences."

Layn looked at his sisters. Neither of them looked toward the upper galleries where the Matron Mother's chambers lay.

He understood only that he was being watched.

Dreydre opened the door wider and pointed toward the bed. "Lie down."

Layn's voice tightened. "I do not want to."

Greyanna slid from the sill, her expression hardening as his refusal lasted. "You are a male in House Freth. Wanting is not a reason."

Dreydre waited until he looked at her. "Lie down, boy."

Layn stepped into the room.

He removed his boots and climbed onto the bed without taking his eyes from the spiders. The first moved when the mattress dipped beneath his weight. Its legs touched his wrist.

He flinched.

Dreydre watched his trembling hands. "Still."

The word carried no anger. That made it worse.

Layn pressed his hands flat against the blanket. The spider climbed across his arm, its weight light enough to be almost gentle. The second followed, crossing his chest and pausing below his throat.

His heart beat so hard that he was certain his sisters could see it.

His eyes burned. Tears slid from the corners into his hair, and he did not move to stop them.

He reached for the pressure behind his eyes, the way he had reached when he named the sleeve. Nothing answered. The fear stood where the quiet had been, and the quiet would not come.

Then the pressure returned on its own.

For one instant the room seemed to draw inward. The spider on his chest stopped moving, its legs folding against its body as though it had struck an invisible barrier.

Dreydre saw it.

Layn knew she saw it because her breathing changed.

Then the pressure vanished, and the spider continued toward his throat.

Neither sister spoke.

They left him there when the household lamps dimmed again, closing the door behind them.

Layn remained still until the spiders had finished exploring the bed. He did not kill them. He did not drive them away. He did not call for a servant.

He lay beneath the sacred animals of Lolth and listened to the house move around him.

He was ten years old, and he did not sleep. The scraping stopped, and he did not move even then.

Chapter 6

The Small Corrections



By twelve, Layn had learned that the training gallery was the only room in House Freth where a mistake was allowed to have a reason.

The floor had been worn smooth beneath generations of feet. The walls carried the shallow scars of practice weapons striking stone. Along one side of the chamber stood orderly racks of staves, swords, short blades, and heavier weapons meant for bodies stronger than his. Nothing in the gallery was decorative. Every object had a use, and Zilvrae expected that use to be understood.

There were no other boys in House Freth for Layn to measure himself against. Noble houses did not produce children in such numbers. A child might be absent from one household for years before another was born, and Layn was the only young drow of his age under House Freth's roof.

Zilvrae therefore measured him against older lessons. She had taught young drow who were powerful before they were disciplined, quick before they were precise, clever before they were patient. She had taught some who learned a movement in a morning and some who needed weeks to stop making the same mistake. She had watched students become arrogant when praised and careless when they discovered something came easily.

Layn had little that came easily: he was neither the strongest nor the quickest. His balance was ordinary, his reach unremarkable, and when formal training had begun, his body often moved a heartbeat after his mind had decided what it wanted.

What he had was persistence; he listened, remembered, and, when Zilvrae corrected the same mistake for the fourth time, he made the correction a fifth time without complaint. When a movement refused to become natural, he repeated it until the awkwardness stopped feeling like an obstacle and became another thing his body knew how to do.

Zilvrae did not care how many repetitions it took. “Again.”

Layn reset his feet. Zilvrae watched the tension in his left shoulder. “Relax it.”

He loosened the shoulder.

Zilvrae gave him no time to settle into the correction. “Again.” The staff came forward. Layn followed the weapon as it changed direction, and Zilvrae stepped around his guard to touch his wrist with the end of her staff.

“You are watching the weapon,” Zilvrae said, and tapped his wrist with the staff.

Layn's eyes stayed on her hand. “I am watching your hand.”

She stopped and lowered the staff, studying him rather than the weapon. “Then you are watching the wrong hand.”

Layn frowned, unwilling to concede the point.

She shifted her weight, barely enough for him to see it. “The weapon tells you what has already happened. The body tells you what is about to happen.”

She demonstrated the movement slowly. The change was so slight that Layn almost missed it: a shift in weight, a turn of the shoulder, the smallest adjustment in the angle of her feet.

“Again.” Zilvrae raised the staff once more.

Layn tried and was wrong. Zilvrae corrected his stance. “Again.” The next attempt was closer.

She struck his shoulder again, but this time the contact was lighter. “Better.”

Layn swallowed his irritation, having already learned that it did not make the next attempt better, and tried again.

This time he saw the movement sooner; he was still too slow to stop it, but he had seen it.

Zilvrae lowered her staff. "Again."

That was how the days went: he did not become brilliant, but he became competent.

The distinction mattered less to Zilvrae than it did to him. She had been assigned a boy to educate, and she took the assignment seriously. His future was not hers to choose. For several years the house would give him the foundations every young drow was expected to possess; at twenty, a young drow would be expected to leave that foundation behind and enter the academy appropriate to the path chosen for him, whether the way of the blade or the way of spellcraft.

Her responsibility was narrower: whatever came next, he would not embarrass her work.

The middle of the day belonged to magic.

There was no sense within House Freth that one kind of education mattered less than another. A noble drow was expected to understand the abilities that belonged naturally to drow blood, just as he was expected to understand a weapon and the structure of the house that owned his place within the city.

Zilvrae taught all three with the same patience.

The first magical discipline took him roughly a month to master as she taught him to perceive magic rather than merely observe what magic did. At first she let him find obvious workings: a ward set into a door, an enchantment on a weapon, the residue left behind after another spell had been cast. Then she concealed weaker traces and made him search without touching anything.

He learned to recognize the difference between ordinary stone and stone carrying a magical working. The next ability, small lights, took several months to master: at first they drifted, then merged, then brightened or dimmed without his permission. Zilvrae made him produce several at once and keep them in different positions, because light was not useful merely because it existed. In a world where darkness was a weapon, controlled illumination could expose what an

enemy meant to hide, force a concealed creature into view, or make one part of a room appear safer than another.

Then came the magic that wrapped a creature in harmless, colored fire.

Its purpose became clear the first time Zilvrae used it on a training dummy hidden beyond the gallery's pillars. The glowing outline made the shape impossible to mistake, and when she attacked it the next instant, there was no uncertainty about where the target's body began or ended. Against something that depended on invisibility or concealment, the value was obvious.

The working itself was less obvious. Layn could create the fire before he could control its boundaries; it sometimes spread wider than intended or settled a finger's breadth away from where he had meant it to cling. Zilvrae corrected him again and again.

Then came darkness, which was not difficult because it was complicated to imagine, but because it had to be placed.

Layn had to learn where it began, where it ended, what it concealed, and what it forced the other person to assume. A careless darkness blinded everyone. A useful darkness made an opponent hesitate while the caster moved elsewhere.

It took him two years to make it do exactly what he intended.

Levitation came later.

The first time his feet left the stone, his stomach tightened so sharply that the spell wavered and dumped him back onto the floor. "Again," Zilvrae said.

There was no object to anchor himself to and no reassuring pressure beneath his boots once the spell took hold, so he had to learn to move in three dimensions while his body insisted that falling was the only honest direction; eventually, he did.

The last discipline was the hardest. Recognizing a magical working was one thing; undoing one was another.

Zilvrae explained it without dressing the problem in mystery. Seeing a blade and using it was not the same as forging the blade. In the same way, recognizing how magic behaved was much easier than

understanding the structure beneath it well enough to dismantle that structure without tearing apart what surrounded it.

Layn never suggested that the task was impossible; he simply spent a very long time discovering how difficult it was.

He practiced the abilities together rather than one at a time. A month after beginning, he could perceive magic reliably while the small lights still wandered. Several months later, the lights held steady while the colored fire remained imperfect. He could shape darkness with confidence while still struggling to unravel what Zilvrae had cast.

None of this made him exceptional. Every drow was expected to learn what came naturally to drow blood. Zilvrae did not congratulate him for being capable; she corrected him when he was not.

“Again.” Layn obeyed, and by the end of the day his palms might ache from the weapons, his eyes might burn from studying magical traces, and his thoughts might feel heavy from memorizing law. For the first time in his life, exhaustion had a different shape: he was not tired because someone had frightened him, but because he had been taught.

At the evenings, they studied.

One evening, after the day's first two lessons were finished, Zilvrae placed an open book before him.

Her finger rested on the first line. “Menzoberranzan contains fifty noble houses.”

Layn waited.

She moved her finger down the page. “House Freth is nineteenth.”

She watched him for a reaction before continuing. “You will eventually understand what that means. Not merely that nineteenth is above some houses and beneath others, but what rank permits, what it demands, and what obligations follow from it.”

She spoke without drama, which was what made the lesson difficult to ignore.

She explained how authority moved within a house, how rank determined access and expectation, and how power could be legal without being equal. A noble male could command those beneath his station and still remain subordinate to almost every female above him. He could possess authority and still have very little freedom.

She taught him the difference between an order and a request, between an obligation and a favor, between something a male could lawfully do and something he could do only because a superior chose to permit it.

Zilvrae tapped the page once. "You are a noble male of House Freth. You have value. That does not mean the house will give you the same authority it gives a daughter. It means you are expected to understand where your authority begins and where it ends."

Layn looked down at the cover of the book, which displayed a female figure holding a scroll in one hand and a scepter in the other. "And if I don't?"

Zilvrae held his gaze. "Eventually someone will teach you by making you pay for the mistake."

The room went quiet. "Learn from me instead."

There was nothing warm in the offer. That made it more valuable.

Zilvrae moved the book a few inches aside and kept her gaze on him. "There is a common mistake young males make. They confuse survival with submission."

Layn raised his eyes.

Zilvrae kept her eyes on him. "Submission is what happens when someone else controls you. Survival is what happens when you understand enough to keep yourself alive."

She watched him absorb the distinction. "Do not mistake a law for a kindness merely because you happen to benefit from obeying it. Neither for cruelty because it opposes your beliefs. Laws are as strict and defined, as colourless and shapeless."

Layn looked confused. If he happened to offend one of her sisters, he thought, the only colourless and shapeless thing would be his corpse lying on the floor.

She waited a moment, then continued. "You may often believe that your position is low and powerless. Remember this: power and expectation are two sides of the same coin. The higher one rises, the more there is expected of them—and the more there is to threaten."

She let the silence hold for a moment. "But threat is a fine whetstone for a drow blade."

Her gaze remained on him. "A blade does not become less deadly because the hand holding it is considered lesser."

She turned back to him. "Strong houses emerge from conscientious drow. Arrogant drow build houses that fall."

She tapped the cover.

Layn touched the cover with one finger. "Is this what happened in your house, too?"

Zilvrae's fingers rested on the hard cover. "Fallen houses are rarely discussed."

Layn frowned. "Why?"

Zilvrae turned the page. "Because there is little advantage in remembering them."

Zilvrae's finger traced the scroll held by the female figure. "Houses turn against one another. It is not rare."

Layn frowned. "Why?"

Her finger moved to the figure's scepter. "Power. Rank. Grievances. Opportunity."

She said each word without emphasis.

"Sometimes the reason matters. Sometimes it does not. Victory has a way of making the victor's reasons seem sufficient."

Layn glanced at the cover, which now looked more familiar.

"The last major change occurred when you were very young," Zilvrae said. "House Do'Urden rose because a house higher in rank ceased to exist."

She rested her hand on the book.

"But that is not a story the city tells."

"What was your house name?" Layn insisted.

Instead of reprimanding him, she opened the book and placed it in front of him again.

Her expression did not change.

“My name is Zilvrae Freth.”

Layn waited.

“There is no other name you need to know.”

“Now, read.”

Chapter 7

Concealment



The spiders continued—always two.

At first they still appeared in his bed often enough that he could almost measure his fear by the calendar, then less often, and eventually not at all. The sisters did not become kinder; they simply stopped needing to come so close.

The physical visits disappeared, but the fear did not.

Layn would lie down and remember the last night in which two spiders had crawled across his bedding. He would inspect the corners before sleeping. He would check beneath the blanket even when he knew there was nothing beneath it.

Some nights he would wake convinced he had felt movement beside his leg.

Some mornings he would remember a dream in which two spiders waited at the foot of his bed and spend several seconds before dawn deciding whether the room was real; once he woke certain that the carved spider above his doorway had turned to look at him, and he remained still, watching it until his breathing slowed and the carving became only stone again.

He never decided whether it had moved at all.

There were other episodes: the certainty that someone had entered a room before the door opened, a shape at the edge of his vision disappearing the instant he turned toward it, or the scrape of something against stone sending a pulse through his body so sudden that his hands were shaking before he understood why.

At first he fought the sensation, which made it worse. Then he remembered Zilvrae: *Do not react to the first movement*. So he stopped, sat still, breathed slowly enough to feel each breath reach the bottom of his lungs, and looked at the room one object at a time—the bed, the table, the door, the carving, and nothing else.

He waited for his heartbeat to stop trying to outrun him.

Sometimes the panic faded in a few breaths, sometimes it took much longer, but he learned not to measure the victory by how quickly it disappeared. The victory was that it disappeared without making the decision for him.

Years earlier, when his sisters had first put two spiders in his bed, fear had frozen him because he had nowhere to put it. Now he had somewhere to put it: he could stand still, breathe, wait, and let the body spend its first answer before choosing his own.

During the day, something else changed as well.

The strange pressure behind his eyes became less frequent, the certainty of movement weaker, and the moments in which something seemed to answer him brief and indistinct. Whatever had once reached outward had become smaller, quieter, harder to summon.

Sometimes he noticed it, sometimes he thought he noticed it, but more often there was simply nothing.

Layn stopped trying to call for it.

He focused on what he could learn by ordinary means.

The house had given him enough work without mysteries.

The sisters remained watchful.

The house remained itself.

And the years passed.

One day she placed several practice weapons on the floor between them.

Zilvrae stepped back from the weapons and gestured toward the rack. “Choose.”

Layn looked over them and tried a sword first. The reach was useful, but he disliked the weight at the end of every movement. He

took up a staff next. It felt more balanced, but the length seemed to announce every intention before he had finished making it. A heavier blade was worse.

He returned to the short weapons and eventually picked up two training daggers, which settled into his hands as though they belonged there.

Zilvrae watched him turn one over, test its balance, then change his grip.

Zilvrae watched his hands settle around the daggers. “Why?”

Layn tested the weight of the first blade and answered without embarrassment. “I’m not good with long or heavy weapons.”

He glanced toward the practice targets. “These are easier to handle.”

He rolled the second dagger between his fingers, considering what else it gave him. “And I can throw them.”

Zilvrae’s eyes moved to the target rack. “Then learn to throw them properly.”

Layn nodded, accepting the correction without argument.

The choice remained his. It was practical and modest, requiring no pretense that he possessed strength he did not have, and he liked it for that reason.

Layn turned one of the daggers over, studying the practice blade before looking back at Zilvrae.

Layn looked at her empty hands, then at the weapon rack. “What’s your favorite weapon?”

Zilvrae stood in the center of the gallery with empty hands, but that did not make it ordinary.

Her fingers closed around nothing, and for a moment the air inside her grasp seemed tighter than the air around it. A narrow line appeared between her fingers, thin as a reflection. It lengthened smoothly, acquiring substance without ever looking assembled, until a dark, faintly lustrous shaft emerged beneath the gallery’s violet lamps, perfectly straight, smooth as polished wood yet without grain, knot, or flaw. The ends formed last, one after another, until there was nothing left to define; then there was a beautiful quarterstaff in her hands, not

ornate but exact in its simplicity. Zilvrae had no interest in ornament. Its beauty came from the absence of anything unnecessary. The balance was exact. The weight seemed to exist in precisely the places a skilled hand would want it. It looked less like a manufactured weapon than an idea of a weapon made solid.

Layn watched her lift it.

The quarterstaff moved as she stepped forward, turned it through one hand, caught it again, and changed her angle without breaking rhythm. It swept, redirected, struck low, and rose again, with no flourish or wasted motion; the weapon did not make her impressive so much as her control of it did.

Layn watched the weapon as though he might find the answer in its construction. “What makes that different from a real weapon?”

Zilvrae's mouth tightened almost imperceptibly. “Nothing you need to concern yourself with.”

She lowered the quarterstaff slightly. “It has weight. It has reach. It breaks things when I tell it to.”

Layn looked at it again. “How long does it stay?” he asked, still watching the impossible blade.

“As long as I hold it,” Zilvrae replied.

She opened the fingers of one hand, waiting for him to notice what did not happen; the staff remained because her other hand still held it, and when she opened that hand as well, the weapon disappeared before it could fall.

Layn blinked, then studied the staff for another moment. “Can you make any weapon?”

“Most,” Zilvrae said.

He considered that answer, then glanced toward the targets. “Can you throw them?”

Zilvrae looked at him long enough to make him reconsider the question. “Not usefully.”

Layn was about to ask why when, instead, she formed a spear.

The weapon appeared in her hands with the same terrible perfection as the staff. When she threw it, Layn saw the point coming straight for his chest for one brief instant.

His body decided before his mind did, and he ducked as the spear vanished a few inches beyond Zilvrae's hand.

Layn's momentum carried the rest of him onward. His foot caught the edge of a low practice stand. He pitched forward, struck the stone with his palms, and ended sprawled face-down with the back of his tunic high enough to expose far more dignity than he possessed.

There was a brief silence before Zilvrae said, in the same tone she might have used to correct his footwork, "Cunning disengagement, Master Laynlindr." Her face remained perfectly composed.

Layn pushed himself upright, red-faced.

Zilvrae had already formed the quarterstaff again. "And now—again."

He got to his feet.

The lesson continued, and Layn looked down at his own daggers, embarrassingly inelegant beside the great staff. He lifted his shoulders slightly and thought, *At least I can throw them.*

Concealment belonged to the same part of the day as weapons.

One morning, in an empty corridor, Zilvrae watched him study the length of the passage before speaking. "Fighting can make you powerful. It can make you feared. It can even make you admired."

She let the thought settle before adding, "It can also get you killed."

She stopped beneath one of the violet lamps and moved deliberately out of the center of the corridor. "Concealment offers something less impressive."

Layn waited.

"Survival," Zilvrae said.

She stepped away from the center of the corridor.

At first he could see her perfectly.

Then servants passed.

They moved around the place where she stood without looking directly at her.

A priestess crossed the adjoining passage.

Her eyes slid past Zilvrae.

Layn frowned.

He knew exactly where she was. He was looking straight at her.

The priestess did not see her.

Zilvrae had not vanished.

She had simply become irrelevant to the attention passing through the corridor.

A servant stopped and turned toward Layn.

Instinctively, he looked away from Zilvrae.

When he looked back, she was gone.

He checked the corridor.

Nothing.

The doorway.

Nothing.

The pillar behind him.

Nothing.

Layn stared at the empty corridor. "Where—"

"Do not ask," Zilvrae said from close enough beside him to make him turn.

She stood beside the same pillar he had already inspected.

The trick had not been invisibility.

It had been attention.

"Again," she said.

This time Layn understood before she explained.

He looked around the corridor.

Then he smiled despite himself.

"Again."

Zilvrae's expression barely changed.

"Good."

From that day forward, concealment became part of his physical education.

She taught him where the eye naturally rested and where it tended to slide away, how to stand without presenting a shape that demanded attention, how to cross a room during the instant when someone else's attention was already occupied, how to move without letting the stone announce his weight.

He learned the difference between hiding and being overlooked.

The first required a place to hide. The second required understanding the person who might be looking.

He practiced both.

At first he was terrible.

Then merely bad.

Then tolerable.

Years later, someone could walk past him at arm's length and fail to notice him if they had no reason to expect him there.

The progress was not dramatic.

It was earned one correction at a time.

Chapter 8

The Long Quiet



The first time Layn saw the lower laboratories was accidental.
He had been avoiding his sisters.

He saw them at the far end of a corridor and turned before either noticed him. By then he had learned to choose the edges of passages automatically. He slipped into the darker side of the hall, became part of the stone, and waited.

A priestess approached from the opposite direction.

Layn did not move.

She stopped at a heavy iron door.

The woman glanced down the passage, saw nothing worth noticing, and pulled it open.

Layn remained still.

She stepped through and immediately broke into a run.

She never saw him.

The door began to swing shut.

Layn caught it.

He waited several breaths.

Then he looked inside.

He had never seen that part of House Freth.

The laboratories lay deep beneath the inhabited halls. The stone there was darker and damp in places, marked by old stains cleaned so often that the effort had left its own pattern. Metal tables stood beneath harsh violet lamps. Glass vessels lined the walls. Cages occupied several corners. Other tables held instruments constructed from metal, crystal, bone, and materials Layn could not name.

Priestesses moved from station to station.

Nobody spoke loudly.

Nobody wasted movement.

The room smelled of heated glass, bitter herbs, metal, old blood, and something chemical that burned faintly at the back of his throat.

He should have left.

Instead he remained beside the door.

A tiny creature, small enough to fit in one priestess's hand, was placed inside a glass enclosure.

Another priestess arrived carrying a dark vessel and measured out a precise amount. Nothing happened until the creature convulsed.

Its body expanded with a violence that made Layn's stomach tighten; its limbs lengthened, its torso thickened, and flesh pushed outward with impossible speed until the tiny animal became a swollen, distorted thing battering the enclosure hard enough to make the metal frame shudder.

The priestesses reacted immediately: one raised a barrier, another shouted an instruction, and two more moved into position as the creature struck again.

The glass fractured, but the containment field held, barely.

Layn could not move.

The monster screamed, and then the transformation began to fail.

Its body shrank, its limbs twisting inward as the enormous shape convulsed once, then again, until the enclosure filled with a wet, violent sound and the creature collapsed into itself.

Silence followed.

No one hurried to mourn it; one priestess began repairing the damaged apparatus, another gathered the remains, and a third picked up a writing instrument and began recording what had happened.

Layn backed away, closed the iron door without making a sound, and returned to the upper halls. He told no one—not his sisters, not Zilvrae, not anyone.

Weeks later, during the theory portion of the day, Layn asked a question he had been carrying since the laboratory.

Layn kept his eyes on the page. "Can a substance amplify something that is already present?"

Zilvrae's pen stopped.

She looked at him over the edge of the page. "Why?"

Layn hesitated. "I was wondering."

Her eyes narrowed slightly. "That is rarely a sufficient reason."

He expected the question to be dismissed. Instead she rose, crossed the room, and returned with a recently written House Freth volume.

She set the book before him. "I have no expertise in such things. But the house keeps records."

She opened the book.

The illustrations were worse than Layn expected.

They showed bodies enlarged beyond ordinary proportion, limbs changed into unfamiliar shapes, mouths opened too widely, muscles swollen until anatomy became difficult to recognize. Some drawings were clinical and precise. Others looked almost like diagrams made from nightmares.

Layn turned to the written page.

The text was remarkably calm.

"The black preparation does not create a capacity absent in the subject. It increases the expression of a capability already present."

He read the next line.

"The preparation is not suitable for strong subjects. A subject possessing sufficient physical strength or resilience will perish upon ingestion."

Layn's eyes moved downward.

"The stronger the subject, the shorter the period of effect. In sufficiently strong subjects, death is immediate."

He paused.

Below it, another line continued the entry.

“In weak subjects, the preparation may persist considerably longer. The visible enlargement and alteration of the subject may therefore be observed for a greater duration.”

Layn looked back at the illustrations.

The drawings suddenly made more sense.

He continued reading.

“Duration varies according to the subject. Physical expenditure increases with the magnitude and duration of the transformation.”

He turned the page.

The writing continued in the same detached hand.

“The white preparation produces the opposite effect. It interferes with the subject's ability to channel the relevant capability for a comparable interval. Physical endurance remains after the interruption.”

There was no warning beyond the observations, no moral judgment, only records.

Layn looked from the page to the illustrations, then from one entry to the other. “So one raises what is already there.”

Zilvrae watched his face. “For a brief time.”

“And the other lowers it.”

Zilvrae nodded. “Yes.”

“It doesn't create anything?”

Zilvrae shook her head once. “No.”

Layn returned to the black preparation entry. “Then the weaker the subject...”

Zilvrae held his gaze. “The longer you may observe the result.”

Layn said nothing.

Zilvrae closed the book. “That is enough.” He opened his mouth, but she set the volume aside. “We continue.” He nodded and she returned to the lesson.

He did not tell her that he had seen the black preparation used.

She did not ask.

Over the years, the three lessons gradually became one uniform education: combat taught Layn what his body could do, magic taught him what his blood could do, and texts taught him what he was allowed to do.

Some evenings, when the final lamp in his room had burned low, Layn would sit on the edge of his bed and consider how strange that distinction was.

The house had begun by teaching him what not to touch; now it was teaching him how to survive touching everything else.

He checked the room and the bedding before lying down, then listened. Nothing.

The quiet did not reassure him, not completely.

He had learned too young that silence could simply mean that something had not started yet.

Still, he learned to lie down and to sleep, at least sometimes. He didn't remember when the last spider incident had been; only the nightmares remained.

A few years earlier, the conversation that changed the method took place without him.

Dreydre and Greyanna stood with Zilvrae in one of the smaller chambers of House Freth.

Greyanna watched Zilvrae carefully. "He is becoming quieter."

"That was the intention," Zilvrae replied.

Greyanna's eyes narrowed. "The manifestations are weaker."

"Yes."

Dreydre frowned. "He used to reach."

"And now he doesn't," Zilvrae said.

The sisters exchanged a look.

"I am more concerned about his training progression," Zilvrae continued. "He is not resting properly."

Dreydre's mouth curved. "If a few spiders are enough to keep him awake, perhaps he deserves the exhaustion."

Zilvrae's expression did not change as her gaze remained on Dreydre. "It has slowed him from completing his training."

"That has never stopped him from completing his lessons," Dreydre replied.

Zilvrae kept her gaze on the sisters. "It has slowed him."

Greyanna crossed her arms. "Fear works."

Zilvrae did not move. "I have not said that it doesn't."

"Then why are you arguing with us?"

Zilvrae remained calm. "I am arguing for the continued development of my student."

The sisters bristled at the word.

Zilvrae folded her hands behind her back. "A frightened boy will freeze when frightened. That is useful."

She let the silence become uncomfortable. "But a disciplined boy can freeze when he chooses to."

Dreydre's expression hardened. "You want us to stop."

"No." The answer caught them both.

Zilvrae kept her hands behind her back. "I want you to understand that I do not want a weak student."

"Fear does not make him weak," Dreydre said.

Greyanna opened her mouth, but Zilvrae spoke first.

"You have achieved the immediate result. He no longer reaches for what frightened him. There are no visible manifestations now. Good."

She looked directly at them.

Zilvrae held Dreydre's gaze. "But fear is a poor long-term teacher."

Dreydre said nothing.

After a moment, Zilvrae asked, "How long do you intend to continue putting spiders in a boy's bed?"

Neither sister answered.

"He will stop being a boy."

Her voice remained level.

“You cannot frighten childhood out of him forever,” Zilvrae continued. “Eventually the same fear you use to control him will be carried into adulthood, where it will become exhaustion, distraction, poor judgment.”

Greyanna's expression tightened. “Discipline is not the same as fear.”

Zilvrae did not hesitate. “No. That is precisely my point.”

She stepped toward the table. “One can live with discipline.”

Her eyes moved between them. “One cannot live indefinitely in expectation of pain without the expectation changing the person.”

Zilvrae drew a slow breath. “I have better uses for my time than spending a decade training a drow whose first instinct is fear. How long do you expect him to survive beyond these walls like this? At this point, you might as well kill the boy and save me the—”

The door opened with a faint squeak.

The Matron Mother entered.

The sisters straightened immediately, Zilvrae bowed her head, and the Matron Mother said nothing as she listened.

Zilvrae addressed the Matron Mother without lowering her eyes. “The boy's progress is slowing. He completes every task, but his rest is poor. The fear is no longer necessary to maintain his restraint. I can teach him to control himself.”

The Matron Mother considered her in silence. “And you believe that is more effective?”

Zilvrae met the Matron Mother's gaze. “In the long term.”

A silence followed as the Matron Mother looked at Dreydre, then Greyanna.

Neither challenged Zilvrae.

The decision was made. The spiders would no longer be necessary, not because House Freth had grown merciful, but because discipline was sustainable; the fear had done its work.

Chapter 9

The Last Lesson



By nineteen, the last day of his instruction arrived without ceremony.

The room was empty when Zilvrae entered.

Another drow from the household came with her, carrying a slate and speaking in the distracted tone of someone discussing a problem too small to deserve anyone's full attention.

The other drow shifted the slate under one arm. "The shipment from the lower galleries is delayed."

Zilvrae took the slate from him. "Then the stores will complain."

"They already have."

She set it on the table. "Replace the damaged seal before they do."

They discussed a broken inventory marker, missing lamp oil, and the condition of the practice weapons. It was ordinary House Freth business, the sort of conversation that could happen in any room where the house's daily affairs were handled.

The other drow left, the door closed, and the room was empty while Zilvrae waited.

"You can come out now."

Nothing happened until Layn stepped away from the wall beside the weapons rack.

He had been visible the entire time.

His clothing blended with the dark stone and the hanging practice gear. He had chosen a position no one naturally looked at because nothing in it suggested that a person belonged there.

Zilvrae regarded him. Her eyes remained on his hiding place. “Acceptable.”

“I thought so,” Layn replied, letting a small smile escape.

Her expression remained unchanged. “That was not praise.”

Layn allowed himself the smallest smile.

He crossed to the weapon rack and picked up his daggers.

They were real steel, physical weapons maintained with care despite being used for training. Years of practice had smoothed their grips and left tiny marks along the edges, but the blades were clean, balanced, and sharp enough to deserve respect.

Zilvrae carried nothing, and when Layn looked at her empty hands, the familiar distortion appeared, sharpening his attention despite himself.

A narrow line formed between her fingers, lengthened, thickened, and became the sword.

He had seen the weapon appear more times than he could count, yet he still watched it.

Layn looked at the manifested sword. “Last time?” he asked, already knowing the answer.

“Last time,” Zilvrae replied, adjusting her grip.

They began, with Zilvrae moving first.

The quarterstaff came across his guard hard enough to force him back. Layn angled away, stepped inside the reach, struck once, and withdrew before the quarterstaff could catch his wrist.

She followed as he changed levels, matched him, and watched him feint left and cut right only for the quarterstaff to meet the attack before the dagger arrived.

He was neither stronger nor faster; what he had was ten years of preparation.

He knew how far the quarterstaff could reach. He knew how much room she needed before the weapon became dangerous. He knew that trying to overpower her would only shorten the fight.

He stepped back, drew Zilvrae forward, changed direction, and threw one dagger.

She slipped aside, the blade striking stone, and Layn did not chase it.

His remaining hand drew the second dagger.

He attacked again.

The second throw came low, but Zilvrae knocked it away with the quarterstaff, leaving Layn unarmed.

For an instant he saw two knives lying several paces apart and a tutor standing between him and both.

He did not rush; instead, he changed the room.

Darkness swallowed the gallery.

Zilvrae stopped, then broke the darkness with a dispelling gesture.

By then, Layn had found both daggers by touch and returned them to his hands.

The gallery was visible again, but he had already moved from the position Zilvrae last saw him.

Zilvrae looked toward the places where a fighter might naturally hide: behind the pillars, beneath the arches, near the weapon racks.

Nothing. Then a shadow crossed from the opposite side.

Zilvrae watched for half a heartbeat, and then she saw the error.

The shadow did not change with the shape of a body. For anyone less experienced, it would have looked like the moving shadow of a hiding threat.

Then several small lights appeared.

They drifted across the gallery, crossing and separating, each one controlled with enough precision to suggest bodies moving at different distances.

One bright patch swept across the far wall.

Layn used the distraction to reposition.

He was already above her before she looked up.

Levitation held him against the ceiling, his back nearly touching the stone, one hand curled around each dagger. He had stopped his own movement completely.

Zilvrae ignored the false motion below.

Her eyes searched the room.

Layn waited.

He had spent years learning where attention landed, how long it remained, and when it was safe to move.

She looked toward the floor.

Layn released the spell.

The fall was immediate.

He turned in the air and brought one dagger down toward the opening beside her shoulder.

Zilvrae heard the whistle of the blade at the last possible second and quickly twisted aside.

The blade struck the quarterstaff with a hard metallic crack.

The impact turned Layn sideways.

He landed, rolled, and came up with his second dagger already in hand.

Zilvrae pressed forward.

Layn gave ground, then cut across her line and slipped toward the edge of the gallery. He found an opening and took it.

She closed it.

He changed direction.

She was waiting.

Layn recognized the magical structure around the quarterstaff as he moved past it. He could feel the faint distinction between ordinary wood and a thing that existed only because Zilvrae continued to hold it in the world.

He understood it.

He did not need to dismantle it.

The thought lasted less than a heartbeat.

Then her free hand moved.

Pale flames spread across Layn's body, clinging to his outline and making every edge of him visible. There was nowhere to hide inside the glow.

Zilvrae advanced.

Layn concentrated to break the spell. “Astux!”¹ he shouted from the bottom of his lungs. He had found it more effective to yell out the command to break a spell mid-fight, even though Zilvrae never approved of it.

All Layn cared about that moment was that it worked. The pale fire vanished, and at the same instant he moved.

He crossed the gallery, turned past her shoulder, and came in low.

For a heartbeat, he thought he had found the opening.

He drove forward.

Zilvrae let him.

At the instant Layn's defensive dagger came up to intercept the strike, the quarterstaff vanished.

Layn's dagger cut through empty air.

Then the quarterstaff reappeared on the other side of his guard, between the dagger and his jaw.

The movement was so fast that, for an instant, it seemed to Layn that the quarterstaff had passed straight through his blade.

The end of it struck his jaw, snapping his head sideways and buckling his knees.

Zilvrae caught his wrist before he could fall, turned him, and brought the quarterstaff beneath his throat.

Layn's mind raced. For ten years he had watched Zilvrae use the quarterstaff in almost every way a weapon could be used, and he had thought he knew every movement she could make with it; he had never anticipated that one.

The years were all there: the first clumsy footwork, the repeated corrections, the dagger choice, the understanding of reach, the use of darkness, the controlled lights, the ability to recognize the magic laid over him, the ability to undo it, and the discipline not to react simply because fear or surprise demanded it.

¹ “Astux” is drowish for “extinguish.”

Layn's chest was rising and falling hard now while Zilvrae's breathing remained even. Layn made mistakes, Zilvrae punished them, he adapted, and she found another.

They remained there for a moment.

Zilvrae lowered the weapon and released him.

Layn rubbed his jaw and gave her a crooked smile. "Nice trick."

Zilvrae lowered the quarterstaff. "The combat work is sufficient."

Layn relaxed his stance.

Layn looked at her, rubbing the ache from his jaw. "Sufficient?"

"You are not a great fighter," Zilvrae said.

He accepted the judgment without flinching.

"But you are no longer an easy one."

Her gaze moved from the daggers to the place where the pale flames had vanished. "You know your weapons. You know the powers given to you. You know how to hide. You know when to wait."

She paused, allowing the final distinction to settle.

"And you know when to move."

Layn stood quietly. Zilvrae studied him for a moment. "You learned." The words landed differently from praise, perhaps because Zilvrae did not intend them as such.

She looked toward the place where he had first emerged at the beginning of the lesson.

Zilvrae lowered the sword. "The training is complete."

She said nothing about the future; that was not hers to decide.

The sound of the opening door interrupted the silence.

Layn turned to find Greyanna standing in the doorway. "The hearing is tonight."

Layn looked at her, trying to read the answer before he asked for it. "Are you going to be there?"

Greyanna's eyes moved briefly toward Zilvrae. "No. My work is finished. From here, you are in the hands of your family."

Greyanna's eyes moved past him to Zilvrae. The glance lingered for a moment, measuring and superior, before returning to Layn.

Zilvrae's expression softened by the smallest degree. "You are going to be decent."

"I always am," Layn said with a faint smile.

Greyanna stepped aside.

Layn glanced once at Zilvrae, then looked away before the gesture could become something he might have to explain. She gave him the same measured look she had given him for years.

The door closed behind them, and Zilvrae remained still in a room that suddenly seemed larger.

For ten years there had always been another lesson waiting, another correction, another mistake, another reason to say the same word until the boy understood it. Again. Now there was no next attempt.

Zilvrae turned toward the weapon racks.

She began putting the room in order. These daggers would not be used again tomorrow; only the marks in the floor would remain.

She adjusted one of the racks, then adjusted it again even though it had been straight the first time, before collecting the training pieces left near the wall.

Her hands did not hurry, and when the room was finally in order, she stood alone in the center of it.

For the first time in ten years, there was no student waiting for her instruction. Zilvrae looked toward the closed door. "Endure, Laynlindr Freth."

Chapter 10

The Hearing



The chamber was larger than it had ever seemed from the outer gallery — a vault of black stone, warm with the breath of braziers below the dais. The spider-wrought floor watched his every step. The priestesses on the platform held themselves still, and their silence made rank into architecture.

He wore the plain black clothing assigned to a male awaiting judgment. No weapon hung at his belt. His hands were empty.

The Matron Mother was already seated on the raised platform at the far end, with Dreydre and Greyanna standing below the dais and two guard females watching the doors.

Layn stopped where the floor was worn pale and remained there.

They discussed him as though the chamber were empty except for themselves, weighing his memory, discipline, and judgment without once addressing him.

a good memory, adequate discipline, judgment less reliable when he believed he had found a pattern. The daughters spoke of his training, of his obedience, of the ten years of it. Greyanna noted that he learned slower than he should.

The Matron Mother listened without needing to dominate the conversation. The final decision belonged to her, and every female in the chamber spoke knowing it.

Layn said nothing, and no one asked him anything. His future moved back and forth across the chamber above his head while he stood beneath it, hands empty, deciding nothing.

In time the discussion reached the question that had hung over the house for years.

“Has he manifested anything?” The words came from the throne, and the chamber went still around them.

Manifested what? The question made no sense to Layn. He searched the last ten years in his memory — the training, the lessons, the things he had been taught to do. There was nothing he could name as a manifestation.

Dreydre kept her eyes lowered. “There have been moments.” The Matron Mother let the answer hang for a breath before asking, “Moments?”

Greyanna answered quickly, eager to contain what her sister had admitted. “Nothing that held. Nothing repeated on command.”

She was not gathering information the way Zilvrae gathered it, one fact at a time. Each answer was being laid somewhere, and on the throne above them a conclusion was being assembled.

Somewhere behind Layn’s shoulder, while the chamber talked over him, the Matron Mother nodded once to a priestess standing at the platform’s edge, and she hurried out through the hall’s doors.

Then the Matron Mother looked at Layn, and for the first time in his life, her eyes met his.

The chamber became quieter, and Layn did not mistake the look for warmth. She was examining him as the ruler of House Freth might examine a blade brought before her for inspection, turning it once in the light and deciding whether it was fit to be used.

Her gaze remained on him. “Show me.” Her first words to him were a command.

Layn was still trying to understand what the drow who was his mother wanted from him when the doors opened again. The same priestess returned carrying two vessels, one filled with a white liquid and the other with black.

The sisters below the dais went still, Greyanna’s hand finding Dreydre’s sleeve while Dreydre’s eyes went to their mother and stayed there.

Behind the priestess, at the chamber's edge, two more priestesses had already begun to chant, their hands turning through the first signs of a longer working. Dreydre recognized the ritual. Greyanna did too. Along with the two vessels, it told them everything their mother intended: their heart rates quickened. Neither daughter had known the hearing would come to this.

The black vessel smoked though nothing burned; the smoke did not rise, but crawled along the glass like something slow and alive, while the air above the stopper bent the way air bends above a forge. The smell reached Layn a breath later — hot iron, old wounds, and underneath them a sweetness that was worse than either. He knew it from the experiment he had witnessed in the dungeons, where he had seen the black preparation take hold of a living creature before the effect burned itself out.

He recognized both elixirs from those basement experiments, and their appearance from Zilvrae's lessons. Still, he did not understand until the priestess crossed the floor toward him with one arm extended, the black vessel in her hand.

He took a step backward, then another, his eyes flicking desperately toward the guarded door. His face stayed still and his heart did not. He shook his head once, slowly.

He did not want it. It was the nearest he had come to refusing anything in nineteen years.

Dreydre's hand tightened around the edge of her sleeve. "Mother..." Her voice almost failed her. "No. Mother—are you certain?"

The Matron Mother turned her eyes on her daughters, and Dreydre's next word died before it was spoken.

The corner of the Matron Mother's mouth lifted with the quiet pleasure of someone who already knew the answer; there was no haste in the expression.

"My daughters," she said. "You are not afraid, are you?"

Her words were drowning in cruelty. There was amusement in them too. The vessel sat between the sisters and the throne, and she had placed it there herself.

Then she looked back at Layn. Her lips never moved, but the command struck inside his skull, louder than a scream.

“Drink!”

It did not ask. It arrived inside him the way the order to breathe arrives, and his will bent around it and broke. His hand rose. His fingers closed on the stopper. Somewhere far away, the part of him that was still Layn watched his own body obey, and hated it, and could do nothing — could not even tremble on purpose.

He drank. The smoke went down like a swallowed coal, and for one breath, nothing happened.

Then the substance opened him, and the chanting became stronger.

His temples pumped. His vision blurred and began to darken at the edges, and his hearing ran away into echoes — and in the darkening, the room came closer than his eyes had ever brought it. He perceived them without looking: the three presences in the chamber, and not their robes or their faces but their essences, each one a shape his mind could read like a page. He felt that he could speak to them if he wished, without moving his lips or his tongue. His body felt weightless. Every part of it answered him the way a limb answers. He felt that he could take the matter of the chamber apart and remake it — form blades out of virtually nothing, thin enough to cut steel; raise shields out of dust that would turn a battering ram.

Was this the absolute power? A voice echoed faintly from somewhere very far away.

The Matron Mother turned to her daughters, watching them closely as though she expected resistance. “Two drops each.”

The white vessel breathed a thin, white smoke that had no smell and no taste.

Dreydre looked at the pale vessel a moment longer than pride allowed before drinking her two drops; Greyanna drank hers as well. They remained what they were—elder priestesses of House Freth, trained and dangerous—but they were deliberately, measurably less.

The sisters had understood their mother’s plan by then, and it showed on their faces.

The Matron Mother extended her hand. Greyanna carried the white vessel to the throne and gave it over. The Matron Mother shook it gently, once, and held it the way a person holds a drink.

As the chanting rose to a peak, a black disc opened beneath the center of the chamber—not a shadow, not a stain. A hole in the world. It spread outward, consuming the stone tile by tile, and where it passed, the floor ceased to be floor. The darkness followed the walls upward, folding them into a cylinder with no ceiling that Layn could find. The braziers went out. The doors vanished with it.

The Matron Mother's throne did not move. The world changed around it, and she sat precisely where she had been, robes settled, hands quiet, in an arena alien and enormous — and she sat in it the way she had sat in her chamber.

The chanting now came from outside the dark, distant yet still loud enough to feel.

The cage was the ritual's work. What it held was theirs.

Inside the dark, something reached into each of them, took hold of what was innermost, and made it stand.

Layn's came first, rising out of him the way the pressure rose behind his eyes—a thin, upright silhouette, warrior-shaped in the way a half-remembered thing is. Now and then it lost its shape, running like liquid before reforming. When it stood, it made a sound that was not a battle cry of anything living: a long, scraping shriek, like nails drawn across hard rock.

The training he had received was of no use here. This was not a fight of staves, blades, or spells he had practiced. Whatever had been pulled out of him had its own instincts, and Layn had never been taught how to use them.

The sisters answered what they saw as Dreydre and Greyanna changed where they stood, their forms rising tall and robed, crowned with eyes, their robes running down into columns of shadow that ended in spider legs. They were large enough that drow beneath them would look like children at the feet of statues.

The sisters moved together.

The figures struck from opposite sides, not like fear but like drills Layn had never been given. One herded him; the other punished the opening. He caught a blow meant for his head and took the follow-up in the ribs, and the silhouette staggered with him. He swung at a figure and his fist passed through shadow, and the shadow's counterstrike put him on one knee.

They were experienced priestesses, coordinated by a discipline of spiritual combat drilled into them all their lives. The last ten years of watching Layn had only told them exactly where he would be weak.

The amplifier roared inside him, and none of it was the same as knowing what to do.

Then, on the floor of the dark, something changed. It was not thought; thought had nothing to do with it. The silhouette stopped reacting to the shades and began arriving where they were going to be — half a breath early, then a full breath early. Strikes that had been finding him began finding only air. Somewhere inside him, the thing the amplifier had torn loose was learning, and it learned the way a starving animal discovering it has claws.

He came up off the floor, and his spirit was larger than it had been.

The sisters did not become fools; they saw the change and adapted with it. They stopped pressing and started provoking — and they had ten years of material. The figures wove his own history out of shadow: the scrape of legs on cloth, the weight of a spider crossing his chest, a door standing open. The things they had used to bury his gift became the things they turned against him now, and it worked, because it had always worked.

Layn fought wild. The silhouette swung too hard and reached too far, and the figures punished every surge of feeling. For a while, it was enough, but not for long.

The figures bore him down again and again until the last blows put him on the floor and kept him there. He folded small — knees to his chest, arms over his head — and the two spider-shapes stood over him, bearing down, again, the way they had always borne down.

In the middle of it, Layn saw himself.

Countless nights. The same position in his bed — knees drawn up, blanket over his head, breathing small — and the two spiders slithering across the folds, slow and deliberate, waiting with him for the night to end.

Through the pain, Layn gathered himself around the only certainty he could still control.

“No more,” he whispered.

The words were barely audible, but they belonged to him.

The blast came out of him and out of the floor at once. It took the two spider-shapes and threw them to opposite ends of the arena, and for a moment the dark between the three of them stood empty.

Now Layn saw clearly, and the shapeless form that had fought for him became fine: a thin-limbed silhouette, upright and steady where everything else in the arena was noise.

It stood the way Layn stood at the foot of the dais: still, and waiting, and impossible to read. In its hands, two blades of pale force formed, one in each. They were thin and exact, quiet the way the pressure behind his eyes was quiet. They were not copies of the weapons he had trained with. They were the weapons his mind reached for first.

They had been shaped to give the two spiders that had haunted him for ten years their final blow.

The spiders regrouped, coming together at the center of the dark with legs coiling, weight settling, and the tension of a battery gathering in their limbs—a coordinated attack. Layn knew where they would hit before they started. He knew it without thinking, the way he had known where the silver pin was, and the order of the thirty house emblems more than ten years ago.

His legs buckled, then he jumped, rising high and fast enough that the spiders thought he had vanished from the arena; by the time he landed, it was his turn.

The assault came at a speed nothing in the chamber had ever shown. The silhouette moved through both figures like a thrown blade, and around it, of its own will, a barrier of energy hardened — a sphere of pale force, seamless. The spiders mimicked him, each

raising a barrier of its own — theirs cracking with explosive light where his was smooth.

For the first time in his life, his sisters were afraid of him, and Layn sensed it in the figures' faces—no longer smiling, no longer flawless, no longer superior.

All three siblings screamed—one cry out of three shapes, none of it made by living throats—and marched for the final clash.

“Enough.” The Matron Mother stood.

She had not moved until that instant. She had watched the arena, the figures, and the awakening without giving the others anything to read.

The word struck through the darkness louder than the clashes.

The three siblings stopped where they stood—Layn mid-stride, his sisters frozen inside their charge.

As the isolated dark cage turned transparent, Layn saw a silhouette levitating in a void, as if it were the only structure in the universe. A spirit stood in the void, so vast that the whole cage rested in the palm of one of its hands — a cylinder the size of a hall, held like a stolen thing. It was a spider, and it was a woman, and it was neither, and every part of it was more than the mind could hold. The sisters' spirits were two candle flames inside the cage. The silhouettes, which had been terrible a breath earlier, looked small. Looked young.

Her power was not larger than theirs but of another kind entirely, the way the mountain is not larger than the stone at its foot.

Layn resisted, but it did not matter.

One thought laid the silhouette flat against the black floor, and Layn felt it in his own body, in his own ribs, and in the floor of his mind; through it, he felt her pure cruelty.

The titanic creature shattered the cage as if it were glass, and the space around the three senseless siblings immediately altered into the familiar great halls of House Freth.

The house's mighty Matron Mother stood emotionless upon her throne.

The manifestations went out like lamps: the figures folded down into Dreydre and Greyanna, while the silhouette came apart into the pressure behind his eyes and vanished. The broken dark ran downward like water finding a drain, the black disc shrank beneath the stone, and the chamber of House Freth assembled itself around them piece by piece, brazier by brazier, as though nothing had happened except to the bodies standing in it.

The chanting had stopped.

A few moments later, Dreydre was on her knees, understanding that her legs had failed.

The other priestesses were already moving through the aftermath — tending Greyanna, whose hands would not stop shaking; steadying the two guard females, who had seen nothing from the doors and would be of no use to anyone while the battle of the Freth held.

Layn was worse, lying where the ritual had dropped him on the pale, worn stones his feet had claimed at the beginning, breathing heavily. His eyes were completely white. Thin black smoke curled from the corners of his mouth with every breath, and the features of his face seemed drawn inward, as though something had sucked them toward the bone of his skull. He did not move. The amplifier had torn his gift open and pushed it through a body that had never been built to hold it.

From the floor, Dreydre watched him; she could not stand, and she could not look away. She had spent ten years making sure this power stayed small and had never once imagined it large. Now she had seen it, and her arms ached, and her ceiling was still shut, and she understood that the lid her mother had pressed over her had been a mercy — to her.

From her throne, the Matron Mother surveyed the aftermath.

She did not consult anyone or ask for an assessment. Her daughters lay defeated, and there was nothing in her face that suggested she needed confirmation.

“Melee-Magthere,” she said, giving the decision its name. Layn did not hear it; he was past hearing.

She rose and walked to the doors at the pace the household adjusted itself to, then stopped without turning toward them.

“Keep him alive.” She offered no explanation and waited for no response before she was gone.

Glossary



Academy — A drow educational institution for young drow. Divided into three schools: in Arach-Tinilith (clerical), Sorcere (magic), and Melee-Magthere (martial).

Amplifier — A substance or magical preparation that intensifies a capability already present in its subject.

Archmage — The highest-ranking arcane authority associated with Menzoberranzan. The Archmage controls the daily heating of Narbondel.

The Bazaar — A major marketplace of Menzoberranzan where merchants, craftsmen, slaves, and travelers conduct business.

Dreydre — Daughter of the Matron Mother of House Freth and one of Layn's elder sisters.

Drow — The subterranean elves who inhabit Menzoberranzan and other parts of the Underdark.

Duthcloim — A commercial district of Menzoberranzan associated with merchants, craftsmen, markets, and trade.

Greyanna — Daughter of the Matron Mother of House Freth and one of Layn's elder sisters.

House Baenre — The First House of Menzoberranzan.

House Do'Urden — A noble House mentioned as having risen in rank after a higher-ranked House ceased to exist.

House Freth — A noble House of Menzoberranzan. It is the nineteenth-ranked House and the House to which Layn belongs.

House Teken'duis — A noble House involved in the religious proceedings shown at the beginning of Layn's story.

Lolth — The principal deity of Menzoberranzan's drow society. She is associated with spiders and is worshipped as the Spider Queen.

Matron Mother — The ruling woman of a noble House.

Melee-Magthere — The martial academy of Menzoberranzan. Layn is sent there following the Hearing.

Menzoberranzan — The great drow city beneath the surface world. It occupies a vast cavern and is organized around noble Houses, religious authority, and a formal hierarchy.

Narbondel — A huge natural stone pillar at the center of Menzoberranzan. The Archmage heats it each morning, and the movement and fading of its heat serve as the city's clock.

Narbondellyn — A wealthy district of Menzoberranzan containing estates, shops, artisans, and prosperous residents.

Qu'ellarz'orl — The secluded noble quarter of Menzoberranzan, where the greatest Houses occupy the heights.

Rothé — A subterranean herd animal whose milk is consumed by drow.

Surface Elves — Elves who live above the Underdark. Drow history describes them as the people from whom the drow were separated during the ancient conflict among the elves.

Underdark — The vast subterranean world beneath the surface, including Menzoberranzan and the surrounding tunnels and caverns.

Zilvrae Freth — A female instructor drow. House Freth has acquired her from her fallen House.